

B. P. Mouat, Baker, 75 Commercial Street, Lerwick

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Basil Pole Mouat (1855–1929) ran a bakery at 75 Commercial Street, Lerwick, from some time after 1885 until **10 December 1927**. It closed because the bake-shop had been condemned. He had learned the trade from George Laurence, baker and grocer, and in 1887 he married Laurence's wife's niece. In 1906 the Shetland Times called it "the oldest established bakery business in Shetland".

Unless marked otherwise, everything below comes from the Shetland Times (via the British Newspaper Archive) and from Bayanne.

Timeline

Date	What happened	Source
2 Apr 1855	Basil Pole Mouat born, Park Lane, Lerwick, son of Magnus Mouat and Barbara Ninian	Bayanne I85322
c. 1868 on	After leaving school, he works for George Laurence, grocer and baker, and stays with him "all his early life"	ST 4 May 1929
2 Sep 1885	George Laurence dies at 69a Commercial Street. In October his creditors are called in as "the late George Laurence, Baker and Grocer"	Bayanne I86837 ; ST 3 Oct 1885
after 1885	Mouat and Thomas Smith, Sound, take over Laurence's grocery. Mrs Laurence keeps the bakery at 75 Commercial Street going	ST 4 May 1929
3 Mar 1887	Mouat marries Ann Davidson Veitch in Glasgow. She is a niece of Mrs Laurence (Ann Davidson)	Bayanne I85323
1891	The paper names Mouat as Laurence's "successor" at the shop	ST 28 Nov 1891
by 1893	Mrs Laurence gives up the bakery and Mouat & Smith take it over. She remarries in Aberdeen on 14 Sep 1893. The partnership is later dissolved and Mouat keeps the bakery	ST 4 May 1929 ; Bayanne I85538
Mar–Apr 1906	Two new ovens are built by Jas. Cruickshank's men from Edinburgh. The paper calls the business "the oldest established bakery business in Shetland"	ST 7 Apr 1906
Oct 1906	A fire in the house above the shop damages his stock	ST 20 Oct 1906
Mar 1907	The block's owner gets approval to raise the walls 4 ft and enlarge the shop windows	ST 9 Mar 1907
1 Apr 1908	His Admiralty contract to supply bread to warships at Lerwick begins, "the first direct contract" given to a Lerwick baker	ST 28 Mar 1908
Sep 1917	A fire badly damages his house in Commercial Street	ST 8 Sep 1917

Date	What happened	Source
21 Nov 1927	He announces his retirement. The bake-shop "has been condemned", so the business can't be transferred	ST 26 Nov 1927
10 Dec 1927	Last day of bread supply. The shop at No. 75 is advertised to let	ST 26 Nov 1927
25 Apr 1928	Bakery plant and utensils are auctioned at the bakeshop by Wm. J. Mackay	ST 14 Apr 1928
15 Dec 1928	The Thule Bakery (Gilbert Hunter, John T. Irvine, David Tait), working from the repaired bakehouse at 69 Commercial Street, opens a shop at No. 45 because it can't get his old shop	ST 1 Dec 1928
1 May 1929	Mouat dies at 69a Commercial Street, aged 74	ST 4 May 1929 ; Bayanne 185322

The shop and the building

The shop was at the south end of Commercial Street. The family lived above and next door, at 69a, and the bakehouse was at No. 69.

- **An old house.** In 1891 the paper said Barbara Pitcairn (of the Busta story) once lived here, in her mother's house. It gave the address as **97** Commercial Street, so the street numbers have probably changed since.
- **Numbering.** Mouat's daughter Jessie was born at "73 Commercial Street" in 1887 (Bayanne). The 1927 notices and the photo both say **75**, and a 1932 note says **73**. It looks like one shop under shifting numbers, but I haven't confirmed that.
- **Owner.** Dr J. F. Robertson owned the block. Mouat's shop and Alex. Sutherland's grocery were on the ground floor, with houses above.
- **1907 alterations.** The walls were raised 4 ft, the shop ceilings heightened and the windows enlarged. This may help date the photo.
- **After Mouat.** The bakehouse was repaired and reopened by the Thule Bakery in December 1928. By 1932 Malcolmson & Co., bakers, had the shop.

The business and its people

- **Bread for the fleet.** In 1905 he shared the bread order for the visiting Fleet with J. Groat and Black & Son. From 1908 he held the Admiralty contract on his own.

- **Outside catering.** From about 1903 to 1924 he was Lerwick's usual caterer. He supplied Territorial and RNR dances and sports, the Up-Helly-Aa halls, the county show marquees, regattas and church parades. Reports kept saying he "purveyed in his usual first-class style".
- **Staff named in the papers.**
 - A Mr Johnston was his foreman for many years. He died in 1921.
 - Robert S. Garriock worked as a baker for him before moving to the Steamers Store. He died in 1945.
 - A man who died in 1949 had served his apprenticeship with him before becoming a docker.
 - In 1899 the bakers' association sent him three long-service cards for his workers.
 - He advertised for lads and message boys between 1902 and 1923.
- **The man.** The obituary calls him quiet and unassuming, with "a fund of quiet humour". He took no active part in public life.
 - He was Steward of Morton Lodge (89) of Freemasons for 35–40 years.
 - He went through all the offices of the Lord Clyde Lodge of Oddfellows, which he joined in about 1877.

Family

The bakery stayed in one extended family. George Laurence's second wife, Ann Davidson (1832–1901), was the sister of Janet Davidson, and Janet's daughter married Mouat.

Person	Dates	Link to the bakery
George Laurence	1810 – 2 Sep 1885	Grocer and baker, Commercial Street. Mouat's employer
Ann Davidson (Mrs Laurence)	1832 – 15 Aug 1901	Ran the bakery after 1885. Married Rev. Alexander Gray Yeats in 1893 and died at Skipton
Basil Pole Mouat	2 Apr 1855 – 1 May 1929	Master baker. Buried in Lerwick New Cemetery
Ann Davidson Veitch (Mrs Mouat)	29 Jul 1857 – 18 Apr 1934	His wife, Mrs Laurence's niece. Born at Balerno and married in Glasgow, 3 Mar 1887

Person	Dates	Link to the bakery
Jessie Ann Davidson Mouat (Mrs Laurenson)	9 Dec 1887 – 28 Oct 1939	Married a son of W. Laurenson of Benston, South Nesting, at Woolwich on 25 Apr 1914 (ST 2 May 1914). Widowed, she died in Auckland
Basilina Ninian ("Lena") Mouat	b. 19 Jan 1889	Commercial teacher at the Central School. MBE for war service
Dr Stephen James Veitch Mouat	1 Apr 1896 – 14 Mar 1975	Gordon Highlanders, wounded 1916 and 1918. Qualified in medicine 1926. Medical officer at Hillswick, later South Ronaldsay

The obituary of a Mrs Laughton, who died in New Zealand in 1937, calls her a sister of "the late Mr B. P. Mouat, baker and confectioner" (ST 25 Sep 1937).

Sources

The Shetland Times issues are linked in the timeline. Others used:

- [Obituary, "Mr Basil P. Mouat"](#), Shetland Times, 4 May 1929, p5
- [Barbara Pitcairn and the house](#), Shetland Times, 28 Nov 1891, p3
- [Thule Bakery notice](#), Shetland Times, 1 Dec 1928, p5
- [1932 note on No. 73](#), Shetland Times, 30 Apr 1932, p4
- [Mouat's foreman Johnston](#), Shetland Times, 16 Jul 1921, p4
- [R. S. Garriock](#), Shetland Times, 19 Oct 1945, p2
- Bayanne (Shetland Family History): the family pages linked above. They also note the 1929 inventory of his estate (SC12/36/19, p107) and two Sheriff Court actions in which he is "bread and biscuit baker, Commercial Street" (1902, 1918).

BNA links need a British Newspaper Archive subscription.